coronation. (Sayyids claim descent from the Prophet Muhammad; Akbar's own Muslim antecedents numbered only about ten generations – it was in the thirteenth century that Timur's great-grandfather embraced Islam.) Abul Ma'ali was bundled off to prison, unharmed, but it must have been clear to the gathered chieftains and to all those who heard of this inglorious affair that a new rule had begun, and that it was not Akbar's alone but Bairam Khan's – and that Bairam Khan would have his revenge.

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It might seem as if in all this celebration of Akbar's accession and plotting against Abul Ma'ali the young emperor had ample time to settle into his new role, and his regent to settle old scores. They did not.

On 14 February 1556, when Akbar put on his black crown, he was one of half a dozen claimants to the throne of Hindustan. Its last competent ruler had been Sher Shah Suri's son, Salim; the dynasty had fractured after his death. Now, four Suri rivals of varying talent were in competition. Only two of them are of immediate interest. One was Sikandar Suri, whom the Mughals had defeated at Sirhind. The other was Muhammad Adil,[20] a man as vicious as he was cowardly. He'd murdered his own nephew, a child, for the throne; once, he'd hidden in the women's quarters to escape a brawl in his court. The only good history has to say of him is that he had an ear for music – he is said to have tutored the legendary Tansen, no less[21] – and an eye for talent. Adil appointed a supremely gifted general to lead his army, a general who won him twenty-two straight victories and emerged as the last and most surprising of Hindustan's potential emperors.

Hemu of Rewari began life as a grocer. His was not a large business; in fact, Abul Fazl describes him as one of 'the petty hucksters' in his town, hawking saltpetre in the back lanes of Rewari. Nevertheless, Hemu was enterprising enough to attract the attention of Salim Shah, Sher Shah Suri's son and successor, who gave Hemu a commission to the Suri court. The grocer rose rapidly, until he was handling administrative and financial affairs as the king's trusted aide. When Salim Shah died and the Suri rivals revealed themselves like so many daggers drawn, Hemu was allied – whether by chance or design – with Muhammad Adil. Soon, Hemu discovered that this was not so much an alliance as an opportunity; his